

Eklavya's Way

GUJARAT

VADODARA

Rajasthan

Maharashtra

A makeshift archery academy, where gritty tribal boys practise with little else but bamboo bows and arrows, nurtures hopes of winning international medals for the country at big ticket sporting events

DINESH BHIL

TAKING AIM: BOYS HONE THEIR SKILLS AT THE ACADEMY IN NASWADI

| By Uday Mahurkar |

But for its ambitious sportspersons and their glittering dreams, this mud-plastered and tarpaulin-covered hut could well be the poorest sports academy in the country. Located in the tribal-dominated Naswadi tehsil of Vadodara district in Gujarat, the Eklavya Archery Academy started by Dinesh Bhil, 30, a former national champion, is home to 30-odd day-dreamers. They cook their own meals but their mission is to win archery medals at international events. They are medallists, however, in Indian Archery, where bows and arrows are made of bamboo and which uses little modern materials. This sport doesn't figure in international competitions where the equipment is a mix of metal and carbon fibre. An Indian bow and arrow set costs just about Rs 3,000 while the international one costs more than Rs 1.5 lakh.

The academy which began in 2005 gets inspiration from Limba Ram—the champion from Udaipur who equalled the world record by winning a gold in the 30 mt event at the 1992 Beijing Asian Games. The boys study in local schools and colleges and practise archery in an

open ground in front of their hut. Against an ideal diet which will cost Rs 50 a day per head, these boys make do with food worth only Rs 25 a day. But they show promise. Take the case of Gharakiabhai Bhil, 19, a second year humanities student who has already won three golds at the under-19 Indian Archery school championship in 2006. Similarly, Ramesh Bhil, 21, went on to win a bronze at the 2007 National Games and two golds at the inter-university national games. In fact, 15 of the 30 boys became national medallists after joining the academy.

Eklavya currently has only four sets of the metal and carbon fibre bows and arrows—a generous donation from a Mumbai businessman who saw the boys practise while passing by the academy as a tourist. Dinesh, who won one gold and two silver medals at the 1997 National Championships, says: "Our aim is to win medals at the 2010 Delhi Commonwealth Games and the 2012 London Olympics. I appeal to philanthropists to adopt the academy till 2012 and see the results for themselves." They can make it big but only if the sports establishment helps them out with good equipment. ■